

Breaking up

About 175 million years ago, hot, melted rock, called magma, began to rise up from within the Earth into the land above. This caused Pangaea to split up, or rift, into smaller continents.

The Atlantic Ocean will continue to widen.

The separation of Greenland and North America began 66 million years ago. It continues today.

Africa will move farther north and close off the Mediterranean Sea.

What's next?

By studying the movement of the Earth's plates, geologists can predict what continents will look like 50 million years into the future.

See also

To find out more about what happens when two continents collide, see mountains (28–29).

Seven continents

The continents we have today were roughly in place about 20 million years ago. However, they are gradually and continually moving in different directions.

The Atlantic Ocean is growing at the same speed as your fingernail!

Mid-Atlantic Ridge

This ridge separates the Eurasian plate (under Europe and Asia) from the North American plate. Most of it is underwater, but in Iceland, parts of the ridge can be clearly seen.



Earthquakes These huge tremblings of the ground happen when plates collide or slide past each other suddenly. Earthquakes can destroy buildings and kill many people.

